

ADDRESS THE GLITCHES IN DRDO

SOLUTIONS

The DRDO will go in for technology tie-ups with foreign firms to accelerate induction in services

New decentralised system gives director-generals more autonomy and financial powers. They will be held accountable for delays.

Investment on special training to get science and technology leaders. Will be encouraged to work in universities and undertake mid-career training programmes to enhance skill sets.

Will focus on both technology and products. Need technology to develop new versions of the systems or to upgrade older platforms.

Each service will now nominate one officer for interaction with the DRDO.

gets for self-reliance and task the organisation with drawing up long-term integrated perspective plans.

The reforms come at a time when several of the organisation's long-delayed premier projects are finally turning the corner—it's Arjun main battle tank held its own against the army's Russian-made T-90 tanks during desert trials. The Integrated Guided Missile Development Programme (IGMDP) has concluded with all missiles—Agni, Prithvi, Akash and Nag—successfully inducted. The Arihant, India's first indigenously built nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine, was launched last year, and begun harbour trials this month.

Critics argue that the proposed DRDO restructuring is already outdated and 'defence laboratories' are a relic of the former Soviet Union. "The laboratories need to be merged with PSUs like Bharat Electronics Ltd (BEL) and Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) so that design, technology, manufacturing and support become efficient and customer-focused. This will also transform HAL and BEL from mere manufacturing, assembly companies into defence and aerospace technol-

THE DTC WILL MONITOR the DRDO, formulate its self-reliance policy, identify critical technologies and task the organisation with drawing up long-term perspective plans.

ogy powerhouses like Brazil's Embraer," says Rajya Sabha MP Rajeev Chandrasekhar.

One private sector CEO terms the DRDO's reforms as "rancid wine in an old bottle with a new label" and questions whether they will actually reduce imports. The organisation actually began as an import substitution agency in 1958 and began a defence product-focused approach only with the IGMDP of 1983. Somewhere along the line, say the armed forces, it became an unwieldy pachyderm with a very high teeth-to-tail ratio. The defence secretary committee's report of April 2010 which reviewed the RRC noted that the organisation's "highly centralised decision-making process was not conducive for accelerated R&D". From being a key player in the acquisition process, it became a marginal player and now even its "scientific advice in terms of technical inputs and terms of feasibility studies is not being sought".

Yet, the DRDO is only one leg of the designer-manufacturer-user troika.

"There is no point just reforming the DRDO, it is the entire defence acquisition system that needs reforms," says Vice-Admiral Raman Puri, former chief of Integrated Defence Staff. In the rest of the world, all service acquisitions flow from national security strategy. So, for instance, if the Pentagon's white paper on defence states that the US must have the capability to fight an expeditionary war, then its acquisitions will be the long-range transports and air-mobile forces. India's Defence Ministry is characterised by an absence of strategic defence planning. Instead, what we have are the "Raksha Mantri's Directives" which are loosely interpreted. Acquisitions are almost entirely driven by the services and the defence ministry. These take the form of ad-hoc buys or replacement planning: replacing 10 squadrons of ageing MiG-21s

with 10 squadrons of new multi-role fighter aircraft. "The reforms are welcome as they usher in armed forces oversight on the DRDO but they should have been combined with other long-pending reforms like greater participation for the private sector," says Brigadier Gurmeet Kanwal, director, Centre for Land Warfare Studies.

Saraswat tugs at the heart strings of the armed forces when he urges them to buy indigenously-built systems over proven state-of-the-art imported equipment. "The services have also a role to play in the economic and industrial growth of the country."

"I follow a simple philosophy," says one of the armed forces vice-chiefs who clear acquisitions. "If the DRDO can't give me a system in time, I go and import it because I am meant to fight a war. If we are found wanting, it is the armed forces and not the DRDO will be held responsible," he says. Clearly, these reforms are the last chance for the organisation to read the writings on the wall. ■